

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

International law

BEFORE

1693 William Penn advocates a European parliament.

1806 Napoleon Bonaparte proposes a customs union for mainland Europe.

1927 French mathematician Émile Borel establishes the French Committee for European Cooperation.

AFTER

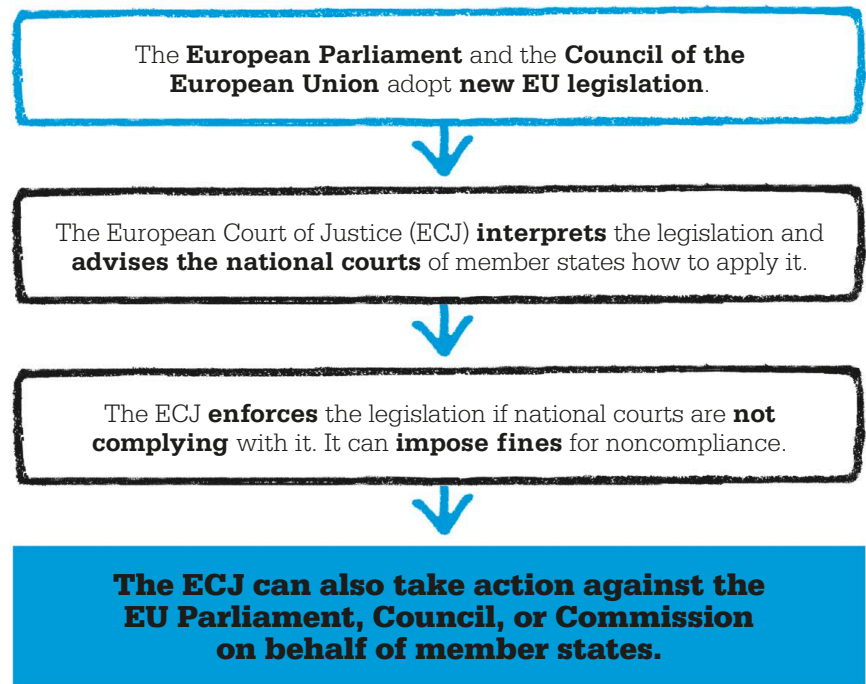
1957 The Treaty of Rome creates the European Economic Community.

1992 The Maastricht Treaty establishes the European Union, a big step toward political integration.

2009 Under the Treaty of Lisbon, new EU constitutional systems are set in place.

2020 The UK exits the EU, leaving 27 member states.

In 1693, English-born William Penn—Quaker, democratic idealist, and founder of the Province of Pennsylvania in America—proposed a parliament for the whole of Europe, as a means to end its constant warring: “[so] that by the same Rules of Justice and Prudence by which Parents and Masters Govern their Families, and Magistrates their Cities, and . . . Princes and Kings their Principalities and Kingdoms, Europe may Obtain and Preserve Peace among Her Sovereignities.” Nothing came of Penn’s plan, though



many others had the same dream—including Czar Alexander I of Russia when the Napoleonic Wars engulfed Europe in 1803–1815. In 1946—after two world wars had torn Europe apart, convincing many that only a unified Europe could guarantee peace—former UK prime minister Winston Churchill appealed for a “United States of Europe.”

Building on that vision, Europe today has two fundamental international organizations: the Council of Europe and the European Union (EU). The aim of the EU is to promote peace and prevent the resurgence of nationalism by means of integration of its member states. It is based on the rule of law, and the European Court of Justice (ECJ) plays an important role in ensuring that EU regulations are observed and applied consistently in every EU country. In 2018, for example, the UK was referred to the Court for being in breach of EU law with

regard to the Air Quality Directive. The Council of Europe (CoE) was set up in 1949, when representatives of 10 countries—France, Italy, the Netherlands, Belgium, Luxembourg, Denmark, Norway, Sweden, Ireland, and the UK—met in London to establish a forum for dialogue and

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The Rule of Justice
[ensures] that Power might
not vanquish or oppress
Right, nor one Neighbour
act an Independency and
Sovereignty upon another.
William Penn
“*Essay Towards the Present and
Future Peace of Europe*,” 1693